I'm a 'paceman'. She mishears underneath all the noise and in that moment, thinks I am a policeman who likes cricket. I find her intimidating – I'm less nervous around Duncan Fletcher and while playing cricket for England – and spend the evening wondering why she is interested in talking to me. She tells me she is 25. *Oh!* I think to myself. *Is that slightly too old for me?*

The next day, I bump into Marcus Trescothick. 'I met the woman I'm going to marry last night,' I tell him. It surprises even me that I've said it. I have not said anything resembling this before. He half smiles, half rolls his eyes. 'Sure you have,' he says, kindly, and gets on with his training drills. I am in the squad but left out of the Champions Trophy first team that plays out the tournament over the next few weeks. It's just as well because my mind is not thinking about cricket. I'm working out what I should text her. I spend the games watching England reach the final before being beaten by West Indies running drinks to and from the pitch, then getting back to the dressing room, sitting next to Gareth Batty as the two of us work out the best thing to say. I am terrified of texting the wrong thing. One bad move and I could blow it. Gareth proofreads my replies, inquisitively asking when innings end and games are over whether she has messaged back and what she has said.

The next time I meet her, at a pub next to the hotel the team are staying at in London, I am completely mesmerised by her. There is something about the way she carries herself, the way she walks, the way she speaks. I have never met anyone like her, male or female. I think I am doing relatively well just by sitting there, not turning red and managing to make occasional eye contact. I know I am being a bit quiet, but I'm having an internal conversation, trying to process the feelings I'm having. Half an hour in, she stops mid-sentence, interrupting her own flow and says, 'Look, you have to start talking. You're going to have to say *something*, otherwise I'm going to leave, and you will never see me again.' I haven't even realised that I am wearing my shyness so obviously. It's hard to explain that the reasons for it are from being overwhelmed and appreciating that I haven't been fidgeting or thinking of a way I can bail by writing an excuse on a pizza box, or running out of the back door of a pub without telling her. I nod, try to catch myself and save the situation, my mind racing around, collecting thoughts and sentences, forcing them out of my mouth against their will. At the end